



YOU ARE **24 WEEKS AND 5 DAYS**

107 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

Here the skin looks almost loose around the neck as the baby has turned their head slightly. This is normal at this stage: the lack of fat beneath the skin and the need to grow rapidly can make your baby appear as if they need time to “grow into” their skin.

“Some meals may be followed by an uncomfortable bout of indigestion, but you can take steps to prevent and relieve this.”

While you may be enjoying your food, you could be paying the price with indigestion. The pregnancy hormone progesterone relaxes the muscles in the entire digestive tract. This slows digestion and the sphincters, or rings of muscles, at each end of the stomach become less effective. This can cause heartburn and indigestion as acidic juices from the stomach leak back into the esophagus. In addition, as your pregnancy progresses, your growing baby is squashing your stomach so that you have a smaller space to digest food.

To relieve indigestion, eat little and often, eat slowly, don't eat late at night, and cut down on fatty or spicy foods. Check with your pharmacist before taking any over-the-counter medicine. You could also try natural remedies, such as peppermint, which is beneficial in its fresh or dried herbal form. Peppermint contains menthol, which has been shown in studies to be an effective digestive muscle relaxant and an effective remedy for gas, nausea, and indigestion. It has a “carminative” effect, meaning that it works specifically on the digestive system. Try drinking tea or sucking on peppermint candy, especially if you've eaten a big meal. If these simple remedies do not work, speak with your doctor about other treatment options.

ASK A NUTRITIONIST

What can I eat to relieve my constipation? Increase your intake of fiber, with high-fiber breakfast cereals, whole-wheat bread, and oatmeal. Eat legumes, such as lentils, beans, and peas too.

Include whole grains in your diet every day, as well as vegetables and fruits. The humble prune not only contains fiber, but also a natural laxative called sorbitol.

Fiber bulks out the stools, but you will need to drink plenty of water to pass them with ease. And don't forget that being active helps, so exercise gently when you can. Don't be embarrassed